



GUILD ATELIER

Why Does Doing It the Wrong Way Make Sense?

AN EXECUTIVE BRIEF FROM GUILD ATELIER

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Every organization has something that people keep doing wrong.

Employees have been trained. The procedure is documented. Management has discussed the problem. Someone has sent an email. Perhaps several emails.

And yet it keeps happening.

The natural management question is:

Why won't people do what they're supposed to do?

That question often leads to familiar responses: retraining, reminders, revised procedures, closer supervision, additional approvals, or disciplinary action.

Sometimes those are exactly the right responses.

But when the same problem keeps returning, there is another question worth asking:

What if doing it the wrong way makes sense?

Not from the perspective of the procedure writer, the quality manager, or the executive reviewing the monthly numbers.

From the perspective of the person actually doing the work.

That distinction can completely change how an organization understands recurring problems.

01

Wrong From Where?

Organizations design processes around how work is supposed to happen.

Actual work happens under different conditions.

There are customers waiting. Production targets have to be met. Managers are unavailable. Equipment is inconveniently located. Information arrives late. Approval takes too long. Two departments have conflicting priorities. The correct tool is somewhere else. The shift is understaffed. The employee has discovered a shortcut that works almost every time.

The procedure describes *work as imagined*.

The employee experiences *work as done*.

When those two diverge, employees adapt.

From management's perspective, the adaptation may look careless, inefficient, insubordinate, or simply wrong.

From the employee's position inside the system, it may be the most rational available choice.

Understanding that does not mean accepting every workaround or excusing unacceptable behavior.

It means treating the behavior as information.

02

When Control Costs More Than the Problem

Consider a small purchasing decision.

An employee needs a \$40 chair. Company policy requires management approval. Perhaps that control exists for good reasons. Organizations need spending controls, purchasing standards, and accountability.

But imagine that obtaining approval requires a manager, a department head, and ultimately a senior financial executive.

The organization has now built a control system in which the administrative cost of making a trivial decision may approach or exceed the value of the decision itself.

What happens next is predictable.

Employees wait. They find another budget. They ask someone with more authority to buy it. They use an old chair. Or they find a way around the purchasing system.

Management may interpret those workarounds as a failure to follow procedure.

But the system itself has made compliance disproportionately expensive.

EXAMPLE

Gary Brose, an entrepreneur who has founded and led multiple companies, took a different approach to small customer-service decisions.

His customer-service representatives were given authority to make reasonable pricing adjustments when needed rather than escalating every exception to management.

There was a cost.

Those discretionary adjustments amounted to roughly \$100 per month.

But that number captured only one side of the transaction.

On the other side were customers whose problems were resolved immediately, employees who were trusted to use judgment, managers who were not interrupted to authorize trivial decisions, and goodwill worth substantially more than the discounts themselves.

The system deliberately accepted a small, measurable cost to avoid a larger, less visible one.

The lesson is not that organizations should eliminate controls.

It is that:

*The scale of the control should bear some
relationship to the scale of the risk.*

Authority also needs to exist close enough to the work to be useful.

When every small exception must travel upward before anything can happen, employees eventually learn one of three things:

Wait.

Escalate.

Or work around the system.

Their choice tells management something about the system it designed.

03

The Potato Salad Problem

The conflict becomes even clearer when both sides are pursuing legitimate objectives.

EXAMPLE

Consider a food-production line assembling prepared meals for supermarkets.

Some ingredients, such as potato salad, are prepared in bulk and divided into smaller containers for use on the line. Each container carries lot and expiration information so the product remains traceable.

The rule is simple:

Finish one container before opening another.

Now consider the worker on the production line.

Trays are moving. Production targets matter. The potato-salad container is almost empty, with perhaps half a kilogram remaining.

The worker opens the next container, pours the remaining product into it, and keeps going.

From the worker's perspective, this is efficient. Nothing is wasted and the line keeps moving.

From the quality technician's perspective, it is a serious failure.

The product in the new container now has an uncertain identity. Even if the two containers probably came from the same bulk batch, the documented traceability chain has been broken.

The line stops.

Production is frustrated because quality has stopped output over half a kilogram of potato salad.

Quality is frustrated because production has compromised a fundamental food-safety control.

And both reactions make sense.

The worker is responding to throughput.

Quality is protecting traceability.

In some cases, production leads themselves encouraged workers to combine containers because keeping the line moving was their immediate responsibility.

At that point, retraining the worker misses the interesting part of the problem.

The organization has placed two legitimate objectives in conflict at the exact point where the work occurs.

The useful question is no longer:

Why did the worker violate the procedure?

It becomes:

Why did the system make violating the procedure useful?

That question leads somewhere very different.

04

“We Told Everyone”

Information creates another version of the same problem.

EXAMPLE

In one food-production operation, the food-safety and quality team regularly identified violations requiring corrective action on the production floor.

The information followed the established management chain.

FSQA reported the issue to the operations director.

The operations director communicated with managers.

Managers were expected to communicate with their teams.

Everyone had apparently done their part.

Yet the same violations continued appearing on the floor.

Somewhere between senior operations management and the people actually performing the work, the information simply disappeared.

Email did not reliably solve it.

Discussing the issue again at the daily operations meeting did not reliably solve it.

So the FSQA team changed the communication path.

Instead of relying exclusively on information to cascade downward through management, FSQA representatives began attending daily stand-up meetings with leads and floor employees.

The information was moved closer to the point of work.

The distinction matters:

*Information had been transmitted before. It
had not reliably become operational
knowledge.*

Organizations frequently confuse those two things.

"We sent an email."

"We covered it in the meeting."

"It is in the SOP."

"They were trained on this."

Each statement describes something the organization did.

None demonstrates that the person doing the work had the right information, understood it, could use it, and had it available at the moment it mattered.

05

Why the Usual Fixes Don't Stick

Recurring problems often produce recurring solutions.

Someone makes a mistake, so employees are retrained.

The problem returns, so the procedure is revised.

It returns again, so management sends a reminder.

It happens again, so supervision increases.

These interventions share an assumption: the primary problem is the behavior being observed.

Sometimes that assumption is correct.

But training cannot remove an approval bottleneck.

An email cannot resolve competing objectives.

A revised procedure cannot make an unavailable resource available.

Discipline cannot make necessary information arrive at the right place and time.

And another reminder not to combine containers will not necessarily remove the production pressure that made combining them useful.

*If the system keeps producing the same
behavior, correcting the behavior is not the
same as correcting the system.*

06

What Is the Workaround Telling You?

The next time an employee does something the “wrong” way, resist the urge to correct it for a moment.

Look at it.

Especially if you've seen it before.

Ask:

What problem does doing it this way solve?

Does it save time?

Does it bypass an approval delay?

Does it keep production moving?

Does it compensate for missing information?

Does it make an unrealistic target achievable?

Does it resolve two conflicting instructions?

Does it give the employee authority the formal process withholds?

Does the organization reward the outcome while criticizing the method required to achieve it?

Then ask the more uncomfortable question:

If I were standing where this employee is standing, with the same information, incentives, authority, resources and pressure, would their decision start to make sense?

If the answer is yes, you have learned something important.

You have not necessarily found an employee problem.

You may have found a system problem.

The Problem Behind the Problem

Managers usually encounter operational problems at the point where they become visible.

A customer complains.

A deadline is missed.

A quality check fails.

An employee violates a procedure.

An inventory number is wrong.

A manager sees the event and naturally tries to correct the event.

But recurring problems leave clues.

If different people keep inventing the same workaround, the workaround is a clue.

If experienced employees ignore the same procedure, the procedure is a clue.

If retraining repeatedly produces no lasting improvement, the retraining is a clue.

If information is repeatedly "communicated" but never seems to reach the work, that is a clue.

If people only comply when a manager is watching, that is a clue.

The recurring problem may not be evidence that the organization has failed to correct its people.

It may be evidence that its people have been adapting, quite rationally, to something the organization has failed to see.

That changes the managerial question.

NOT

“How do we stop them from doing this?”

BUT

*“What do they know about this system that we
don't?”*

That is often where the real investigation begins.

Because when doing it wrong consistently makes the work easier, faster, or even possible, the most interesting thing in the room is no longer the employee breaking the rule.

*It's the system that taught them
why they should.*

*Guild Atelier examines recurring operational problems through
Operational Systems Analysis, looking beyond the visible failure to
understand the conditions, relationships, information flows,
incentives, constraints, and adaptations that keep producing it.*

